

PROMISING RETURN PRACTICES

POST-RETURN GEORGIA

D9.1 - JANUARY 2026

Rodrigo Bolaños Suárez (bicc)
Zeynep Sahin-Mencutek (bicc)
Soner Barthoma (Uppsala University)



Funded by
the European Union

Name of practice	Reintegration programs	
Dates	(No Information)	
Target group	Returnees	
Geographic Scope	Country	Georgia
	Regions	Asia, Europe
	Sub Region	SouthCaucasus
Actor	Ministry of Interior Ministry of Labour, Health and Social Affairs Frontex. International and local NGOs	
Return Stages	Post-Return	
Challenge addressed	Reintegration Sustainability	
Principles referred (implicit or explicit)	Migrants' Agency	

SUMMARY

To improve official reintegration programs, especially during the initial phase of return, Georgian state authorities seek to utilise extensive social networks, to reduce costs and redirect more resources to other support initiatives. Involving local actors with contextual knowledge is crucial for developing effective solutions. Frontex collaborates with local NGOs to create customized solutions for returnees.

1) *Assistance in business plan development.* Returnees who have spent extended periods abroad often lack up-to-date knowledge of local market conditions. Local NGOs provide context-specific guidance and assist beneficiaries in preparing a realistic and feasible business plan. Implementing agencies are also required to monitor the further development of supported businesses, typically one to two years after establishment.

2) *Procurement of goods instead of cash assistance.* Rather than disbursing funds directly, implementing partners supply beneficiaries with in-kind products needed to establish their businesses. This approach limits overpricing and reduces the risk of misallocation.

3) *Assistance with medical issues.* In Georgia, the national health service does not fully cover the costs of medical treatments. Therefore, the possibility of receiving assistance with medical issues is a good practice concerning both the well-being of a returnee and the efficiency of the entire system.

BENEFITS/IMPACTS AND SHORTCOMINGS

The benefits of reintegration programs in Georgia are threefold. First, for returnees, these programs provide the opportunity to gain independence and reduce reliance on social benefits by starting their own businesses. Second, the Georgian government benefits by fostering economic development and lessening the burden on the social security system. Lastly, for the EU, these programs help minimize the risk of returnees re-emigrating and promotes the EU as a solid and reliable partner.

In 2018, there were 815 beneficiaries of reintegration programmes in Georgia, compared with 6,625 total returns. Most assistance targeted returnees from EU Member States, with income-generating project grants being the most common form of support. Also, the programmes have contributed to strengthening mutual trust between the EU and the Georgian state, which could potentially lead to improved cooperation on broader issues, including Georgia's future EU accession.

The main shortcomings relate to gaps in the assistance schemes and errors in program design. There is a lack of psychological support, and some returnees do not receive adequate information during the pre-return phase. Additionally, the feasibility of income-generating projects is not always properly assessed. In certain cases, business plans are evaluated abroad without a full understanding of local market conditions or cultural realities in Georgia. Furthermore, returnees may face social stigma, as there are either negative attitudes within Georgian society towards those who did not stay abroad and were forced to return or high expectations about the affluency of emigrants.

KEY LESSONS

Synergy of actors is key to effective reintegration. The most effective reintegration solutions depend on a synergy of resources provided by various actors working at different levels, with a clear and suitable division of responsibilities. In the case of Georgia, this is illustrated by the complementary roles of Frontex, state institutions, and locally based NGOs.

Pre-return preparation determines post-return success. Reintegration begins at the pre-return stage, where effective communication between return-enforcement authorities and implementing partners is essential for adequately preparing to receive returnees. In Georgia's case, coordinated information exchange between Frontex and local stakeholders enables reintegration measures to be designed according to actual needs and local conditions.

RECOMMENDATIONS

Provide relevant and timely access to information. Strengthening access to relevant information before departure seems crucial for an effective reintegration process. This information should be accessible in strategic places of first contact, like airports, railway stations, and bus stations.

Offer pre-departure training to facilitate employment. Training should be available before departure, so the returnees are prepared to find a job immediately after arrival.

Conduct information campaigns to improve social acceptance. Organising targeted information campaigns can help alter public perceptions and foster a more supportive environment for returnees.

REFERENCES

Jaroszewicz, M., Krępa, M. and Pachocka, M. (2025). "The EU-Georgia readmission agreement as a showcase of the strengths and weaknesses of the EU neighbourhood policy" in GAPs Working Paper Series: 2025/25. <https://doi.org/10.5281/zenodo.17535902>

Krępa, M., Pachocka, M., Trylińska, A., & Sieniow, T. (2024). Externalisation of EU Migration Policies: The Case of Cooperation in the Georgian Citizens' Returns from Poland. GAPs: De-centring the Study of Migrant Returns and Readmission Policies in Europe and Beyond. <https://doi.org/10.5281/zenodo.13134919>

Krępa M., Pachocka M., Trylińska A., Sieniow T., Jaroszewicz M. (2025). WP3 Country Dossier: Return Migration Infrastructures – Poland and Georgia, GAPs Working Paper 2025:18, <https://doi.org/10.5281/zenodo.15750564>.